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The Multi-faceted Role of Confusion in the Production of Knowledge

The term confusion, as per the Oxford Advanced Learner's Dictionary, is "a state of not being certain about what is happening, what you should do, what something means, etc." ("Confusion," def. N.1). Put simply, confusion is some type of uncertainty. I use the phrase "producing new knowledge" and its variations to indicate writing of scholarly works, inventing of new techniques, discovery of new facts and knowledge being more widely accepted, or more well-known. Despite confusion being associated with uncertainty and knowledge being associated with facts (something certain), confusion is seen to play a part in the production of knowledge. In this essay, I aim to determine the role of confusion in producing knowledge. To do so, I close-read quotes from Navaneetha Mokkil's chapter "Living Together, Dying Together: The Politics of Lesbian Hauntings", from her book *Unruly Figures: Queerness, Sex Work and the Politics of Sexuality in Kerala* (2019), Sabine Hossenfelder's YouTube video "How I Learned to Love Pseudoscience" (2021) and Derrick Jensen's "Silencing" from *A Language Older Than Words* (2004). Mokkil demonstrates a way to understand the complex state of lesbian politics in Kerala through her analyses of interviews of those close to the victims of one particular case of suicides involving an Adivasi lesbian couple consisting of Meera — a gender non-conforming individual — and Ammini. Hossenfelder talks about how even though pseudosciences appear to be bad and confusion-causing, they actually help propel scientific knowledge. Jensen, in his chapter, describes why and how the phenomena of humans ignoring harsh truths and facts occurs, and how

that affected and caused him confusion in his childhood. In this essay, I argue that confusion is an impetus for actions that lead to the production of knowledge and that confusions associated with maltreatment or the past cause the production of specific knowledge.

Confusion plays the role of an impetus that causes actions that yield new knowledge. While writing about the scene of the suicides of Meera and Ammini mentioned in the Sahayatrika team's 2004 work, Mokkil says that in Meera's employer Shailaja's memory of the scene, "at the time of death Meera's body [was] displayed before the public to be objectively measured. There [was] an attempt, once and for all, to settle the ambiguities of Meera's gender performances" (183). When alive, Meera's mannerisms were in dissonance with the crowd's idea of a woman which led to them having ambiguities relating to her biological sex — ambiguities, they believe, that would be resolved by "objectively measur[ing]" Meera's dead body. These "ambiguities" about Meera's sex are the confusion the crowd has. This confusion drove them to act and "objectively measure" Meera's body thus gaining knowledge of her sex. Hence, confusion causes actions that lead to the production of new knowledge. However, though actions due to confusion can produce new knowledge, they don't guarantee it. When talking about how some legitimate theories — like the one on the existence of atoms — were previously categorised as pseudoscientific, and how with the perpetuation of scientific knowledge pseudosciences will emerge, Hossenfelder states that "[i]f we learn something new about nature, some fraction of people will cling to falsified theories longer than reasonable. And some crazy ideas in the end turn out to be correct" (02:11). She tells us that with the advance of scientific knowledge, certain individuals still have confidence in false theories and sometimes these theories potentially may not be classified as a pseudoscience in the future. The "fraction of people" having faith in the theories that are considered pseudoscientific by the greater public, tells us that there is uncertainty regarding the acceptance of such theories. This confusion among the populace can lead to actions by the "fraction of people" — actions that are a hindrance to

scientific progress (the action of “cling[ing]” to pseudoscience for “longer than reasonable” means that a lesser number of people accept, hence know about the actual knowledge) or actions that prove these “crazy ideas” true. Therefore, though knowledge can be formed through actions driven by confusion, its production isn’t guaranteed. Hence, confusion is an impetus for actions that may result in the production of knowledge.

While confusion leads to actions, it also leads to maltreatment which allows for knowledge to be generated. This knowledge is directed towards the prevention of maltreatment. Hossenfelder, after telling us that pseudoscience can help ameliorate scientific methods, uses the invention of single-blind trials as an example: “[s]ingle-blind trials, for example, were invented in the 18th century to debunk the practice of Mesmerism. ... [m]any people were [mystified] by the first batteries and electrically powered devices. Franz Mesmer exploited their confusion” (2:43). Hossenfelder talks about single-blind trials being devised to fight the public’s confusion being taken advantage of. The confusion of the public leads to it being “exploited” or maltreated by Mesmer. The technique of single-blind trials (the knowledge) was “invented” (or produced) to prevent this maltreatment. Therefore, the confusion that leads to maltreatment allows for the production of knowledge that attempts to prevent such maltreatment. This attempt at prevention can be in the form of a rise of awareness. Jensen, in the context of us not facing certain situations and happenings due to them causing discomfort, says that “twenty-five percent of all women of this culture are raped during their lifetimes. ... [T]here has to be a threshold beyond which we can no longer ignore the destructiveness of our way of living. What is that threshold? One in two women raped? Every woman raped?” (14-15). Jensen, after giving an example of how dangerous our lifestyle is, questions where the limit at which we can begin to acknowledge this dangerousness lies. Jensen asking us what the “threshold” is for acknowledging our “destructive” lifestyle, indicates that there is uncertainty — hence confusion — regarding what the “threshold” actually is. We can see that

Jensen's tone is ironic by his suggestion of a ridiculously high "threshold" of "[e]very woman [being] raped", just after asking what the "threshold" possibly could be. The recognition of this tone enables us to understand that Jensen suggests that this "threshold" has already been surpassed. This knowledge that tells us that we need to acknowledge our "destructive" living, helps raise awareness on the high frequency of women being maltreated (or "raped"). Rising awareness on this maltreatment is a step taken towards its prevention. Therefore confusion that results in or is around maltreatment causes knowledge directed towards preventing it from being produced.

In addition to maltreatment, confusions have also previously resulted in contentious lines of thought that lead to conclusions which are reflected upon in the works of people. These works being written are productions of knowledge. Referring to Descartes' search for one certain thing in the entire universe that led him to the line of thought that brought him to his famous quote, Jensen says that "[s]earching for certainty, René Descartes became the father of modern science and philosophy. ... his search was fatally flawed before it even began" (10). According to Jensen, René Descartes becoming the pioneer of philosophy and science began with the faulty search for certainty. The lack of certainty that pushed him to "search" is the confusion. This "search", concluded with Descartes becoming the originator of modern philosophy. Jensen reflects upon this "search" and the line of thought it brought about when he describes it as "fatally flawed" for certain reasons — reasons which he delineates in his chapter by drawing upon Descartes' conclusions and the line of thought itself. This delineation is the production of new knowledge. Therefore, the confusion that caused contentious lines of thought in the past leads to the generation of knowledge. A different type of confusion associated with the past — confusion around previous theories — results in the generation of knowledge aimed toward alleviating the confusion itself. Hossenfelder, talking on Karl Popper's discovery, says that "[he] came up with his demarcation criterion of falsification

because he wanted to show that Marxism and Freud's psychoanalysis wasn't proper science" (10:02). Hossenfelder believes that Karl Popper's work was aimed to show that Marxism and Freud's psychoanalysis weren't actually actual science. Popper attempting to show that those previous theories weren't wholly "scien[tific]" means that there wasn't any evidence that deemed the theories not "proper". As there wasn't conclusive evidence that they were false, it indicates that there was uncertainty on the legitimacy of the theories. Popper formulating "his demarcation criterion of falsification" is the production of new knowledge — this production tries to alleviate confusion around the theories' acceptance as it tries to conclusively prove those theories false. Therefore, confusions around works of the past, or those that cause contentious lines of thought, result in the production of knowledge that may be aimed towards alleviating confusion.

Confusion has a multi-faceted role in the production of knowledge. It is an impetus or a driving force for actions that may result in the generation of knowledge. Confusions associated with things like maltreatment, or the past, cause the production of knowledge of a specific nature. The writing of this essay compels me to ask a set of questions that are more contradictory as compared to the one I answered. Are there instances where confusion can be considered as new knowledge? If so, how does confusion become new knowledge? ¹

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Works Cited

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